FOR THE LOVE OF BIRDS

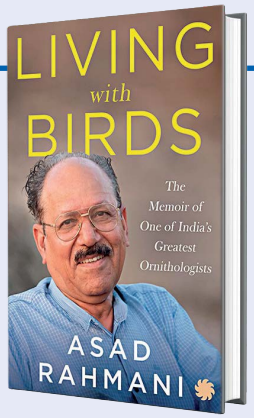
ASAD RAHMANI'S MEMOIR, *LIVING WITH BIRDS*, CEMENTS HIS REPUTATION AS INDIA'S GREATEST LIVING ORNITHOLOGIST

Unlike his famous predecessor Sálim Ali, Asad Rahmani is not a household name. He does not have a Wikipedia page. And, perhaps because he is not on Instagram, the younger generation may be unaware of his immense body of work. Yet, most conservationists acknowledge Rahmani as the country's greatest living ornithologist. His memoir, long overdue, has finally appeared in print.

That it did is fortuitous, not least because the senior conservationist is in his seventies and well-placed to reflect on an illustrious career. In October 2020, during the Covid-19 pandemic, he had a brush with death.

His book's title, then, is apt. *Living with Birds* traces Rahmani's life in ornithology and conservation, much of it undertaken with the Bombay Natural History Society (BNHS), the prestigious organisation where he began his career and later helmed as its longest-serving director.

Rahmani spent his childhood and youth in Lucknow before continuing his education at Aligarh Muslim University. It was here that his wildlife activism began. When a senior faculty member shot a peacock, young Rahmani ensured the perpetrator was brought to justice. Decades later, returning to his alma mater as an academic, he watched peafowl roam freely and felt vindicated.



THE CENTREPIECE OF THE BOOK IS RAHMANI'S EXPERIENCE WITH CONSERVING THE **GREAT INDIAN BUSTARD**

LIVING WITH BIRDS
by Asad Rahmani
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He also fostered a passion for writing, inspired by M. Krishnan's erudite columns on wildlife in *The Statesman*. "The first thing that I bought with my own earnings was a typewriter," he writes. The second thing, purchased with money from his writing, was a second-hand Zenit camera.

Although much of what Rahmani writes has an elegiac ring, given the immense loss of biodiversity India faces today, he remains hopeful. Every ornithological success story of the past five decades worth telling finds its way into the book—from studying the rare Bengal Florican's courtship and the vulture extinction crisis of the late 1990s to an expedition to the remote Andaman archipelago to study the Narcondam Hornbill. His accounts of fieldwork often read like a report on rural India, rich with well-observed vignettes of village life, infant mortality and the persistent inadequacies of rural healthcare.

The centrepiece of the book, however, is his experience with conserving the Great Indian Bustard, whose imminent extinction troubles him deeply. The peacock-sized ground bird, once widespread across the Indian subcontinent, is now critically endangered. Decision-makers